

Combat Virtual Threats with IPCop Firewall



This article is an introduction to the special firewall distribution, IPCop.

In today's world, dependence on the Internet has reached such a level that without it, the day-to-day work of many organisations will come to a standstill. As everybody is aware, when we connect to the Internet, a public IP address is assigned, which is used to access the Internet, and of course, can be used to track the actions from that IP address. The Indian IT Act 2000 and its amendments make the IP address holder responsible for all activities it has been used for. Thus, the management of a company that has subscribed to the Internet connection is responsible for all activities running on its IP address. This applies not only to the management team members, but to all authorised and unauthorised users accessing the Internet using that subscribed IP address.

This 24x7 use of the Internet, business' dependence on it, and emerging cyber laws have escalated the need to control and monitor Internet access like never before. The first step towards establishing this control is, of course,

a network-based firewall. Please refer to Diagram 1 for a typical example of an internal network connected to the Internet using an ADSL router. Good and properly configured anti-virus software, with a personal firewall, will meet the security requirements of most individual users who connect to the Internet. However, for any organisation where multiple users on a network access the Internet, it is absolutely necessary to look beyond these measures and opt for a network-based firewall.

Large corporations with IT security budgets rely on commercially available firewalls for secure and controlled Internet access. These security products can be put to use very effectively to restrict Internet access, as per the company policy. However, they require continuous investment—first to purchase and install the product, followed by yearly renewals. For the management of small and medium-sized organisations, this may be a luxury.